stable month-on-month, remained above both last year's levels and the five-year average. In the Gerardo Barrios reference market in San Salvador, white maize prices were 21 percent higher than the previous year and 17 percent above the five-year average. El Salvador's high dependence on white maize imports and below-average import volumes throughout much of 2025, combined with elevated production and transportation costs, is likely to sustain upward pressure on maize prices, limiting purchasing power and exacerbating the lean season.

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- **At the onset of the rainy season, cumulative rainfall has been below average across much of eastern El Salvador, compounded by above-average temperatures in recent weeks.** While the *primera* planting window runs between mid-May and June, government recommendations have promoted earlier planting (late April to early May), if adequate soil moisture conditions are verified before sowing. Forecasts indicate below-average rainfall and above-average temperatures will persist, alongside a prolonged and intensified *canícula* during July and August, which early planting could help mitigate. These conditions are likely to reduce soil moisture, disrupt crop development (particularly rainfed maize), increase the likelihood of pests and diseases, and limit *primera* yields for non-irrigated smallholder farmers, especially in the Dry Corridor. Although agricultural labor demand typically rises in May with the start of the *primera* season, high input costs and anticipated planting delays are expected to reduce staple-crop labor demand and maintain below-average income.

- **Volatile global fuel prices are likely to gradually increase transportation and agricultural production costs, contributing to additional upward pressure on food prices.** In April, gasoline and diesel prices increased by approximately 12-16 percent compared to March and are expected to remain elevated due to global supply disruptions and El Salvador's dependence on fuel imports. Fertilizer is expected to remain generally available through commercial suppliers and the government-subsidized fertilizer sales and distribution centers; however, higher fuel and fertilizer prices, along with price transmission effects and market speculation, are likely to increase agricultural input costs and limit fertilizer application rates. This will likely further erode household purchasing power, particularly for smallholder farmers purchasing inputs for the start of the *postrera* planting season.

Recommended citation: FEWS NET. El Salvador Actualización de mensajes clave Mayo - Septiembre 2026: Inicio irregular de la temporada de Primera debido a temperaturas y precipitaciones atípicas, 2026.